family in Maharashtra, he went to a Marathi-medium school, graduated in journalism in Pune and then went on to study Public Relations at Boston University.

He is also not entirely new to politics: between 2020 and 2023, Dipke volunteered with AAP's social media operation, where his instinct for digital messaging was already evident. As Ankit Lal, the former AAP social media strategist who worked with him, recalls: "Abhijeet was a maverick. He was always bubbling with ideas. There was something different about him." Yet the CJP has consciously resisted turning Dipke into a personality cult. Psephologist Yogendra Yadav points out that this does not make the CJP leaderless: "They already have leaders... there is a decision-making structure." The attempt is to have leadership without becoming leader-centric.

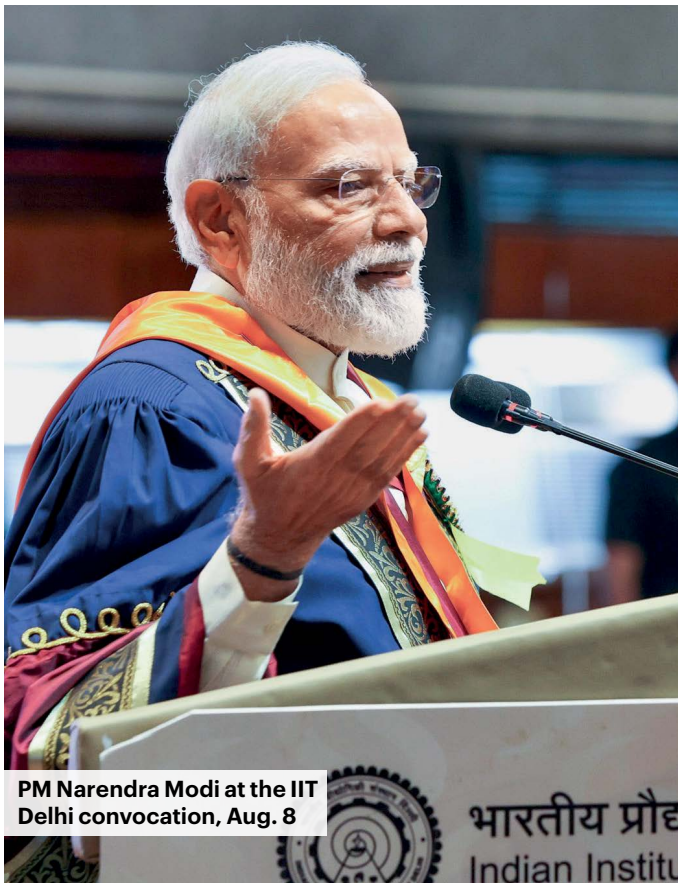
There is another intriguing dimension to Dipke's emergence. Influenced by B.R. Ambedkar, he comes from a community in Maharashtra where education and government employment have historically been powerful instruments of social mobility. Yet he has conspicuously avoided projecting himself as a Dalit leader. Instead, he has sought to construct an identity around generation rather than caste, pitching the CJP's appeal to students and young job-seekers across social groups. That makes the CJP an unusual experiment. Its constituency is conceived not through caste, religion, language or geography, but through age and shared aspiration.

DISCONTENT WITH OLD POLITICS NEED NOT BE ENOUGH TO TRANSLATE INTO ALLEGIANCE TO THE CJP AS THERE IS NO COHESIVE GEN Z VOTE YET

Experts, though, are sharply divided on whether the CJP's decentralised model is a strength or a weakness. Yashwant Deshmukh, psephologist and co-founder of CVoter, points to history: successful mass movements have generally coalesced around a recognisable personality: JP, V.P. Singh, Hazare and Kejriwal.

Deshmukh is sceptical that Dipke currently possesses such a stature. He draws a sharp distinction between creating a successful digital movement and commanding the moral authority and charisma to sustain a mass political mobilisation. "Dipke is nowhere near being a JP or, for that matter, Anna. He's not even one per cent of Arvind Kejriwal," he says. Deshmukh believes the CJP itself recognised this leadership deficit when it brought Sonam Wangchuk into the agitation. Wangchuk lent the movement moral credibility and public recognition, but even he failed to convert himself into its enduring rallying point. "The CJP's biggest flaw," says Deshmukh, "is that it does not have an Anna Hazare-like figure to rally around."

Ghanshyam Shah offers perhaps the most useful formulation: "The larger vision can coordinate it. It might be one individual or a group of individuals," he says. His more important reservation is that the CJP doesn't yet possess that larger



PM Narendra Modi at the IIT Delhi convocation, Aug. 8



Rahul Gandhi at the Congress's 'Chhatron ki Goonj' event, Dehradun, Jul. 17

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR